

Session 41: Reflecting on Jonah's Anger

Key Takeaways

- The author challenges us to think about whether there are people who have done such evil that we want God to destroy them rather than heal them and show them compassion.

"We must be clear where Jonah gets it wrong. It's not as if we should never desire justice ... It is good news when an oppressor is toppled, the terrorist caught, and the torturer brought to justice. The Lord does indeed 'take vengeance on his enemies' (as Nahum says of Nineveh in [Nah 1:2](#)), for he is the enemy of all who destroy his world. But the great danger is that instead of simply rejoicing at the vindication of the oppressed, we self-righteously identify ourselves as the oppressed, taking pity on ourselves and not on others. In our imaginations, the Lord becomes a weapon in our campaign to destroy our enemies, an instrument of our own revenge rather than the righteous judge of all the earth ... But the biblical theme of God's 'repentance concerning evil' means that the God of Israel is more inclined to save his enemies than destroy them ... This has particular consequences for God's covenant people ... It creates a two-sidedness to their calling ... to be the vehicle of God's blessing to all the nations ([Genesis 12:1-3](#)) ... so that their enemies are not necessarily God's enemies ... The repentance of God is not about God changing his mind, but is the fulfillment of his intention to save the wicked, which brings about a new and surprising relation between him and his enemies—surprising to us, but not to him."

Cary, Phillip (2008), [Jonah](#). Brazos Press. 160-161.



This session has no other notes

Reflection Question

God asks Jonah, "Is it right for you to be angry?" What does the text tell us about the reason for Jonah's anger?